DATE: May 20, 2026

TO: School Board

FROM: Kristina Howard, Senior Chief; Filip Hristic, Senior Director for Secondary Academics; Anjene Bryant, Assistant Director for 6-8 ELA and Social Studies; Morgan Hallabrin, Assistant Director for 9-12 ELA and Social Studies

SUBJECT: 6-12 Social Studies Instructional Materials Adoption Recommendation

BACKGROUND

The previous comprehensive 6-12 Social Studies adoption was completed nearly 20 years ago. A significant gap exists between our current resources and the updated Oregon State Standards, specifically regarding inquiry-based practices and the integration of diverse, non-dominant perspectives. This lack of alignment forces educators to spend an excessive amount of time sourcing supplemental materials, resulting in inconsistent instructional quality across the district. Providing updated, high-quality instructional materials is a necessary step to ensure all students have access to rigorous, grade-level social studies content.

BEST PRACTICES

Best practices in social studies instruction are deeply rooted in the framework established by the **2024 Oregon Social Studies Standards**, which mandate a profound pedagogical shift away from traditional, teacher-centric lecture models toward active student inquiry.

- **The Inquiry Arc:** In alignment with these state standards, instruction must utilize the "Inquiry Arc." Rather than focusing on the rote memorization of historical facts, dates, and names, students learn to construct compelling questions, apply disciplinary concepts (such as history, civics, economics, and geography), evaluate primary and secondary sources, and communicate data-backed conclusions.
- **Inclusive Histories:** The 2024 standards explicitly integrate ethnic studies and inclusive histories across all grade bands. Best practices dictate that culturally responsive instruction must build upon the linguistic and cultural assets of our student body. This requires moving entirely away from monthly add-ons, instead utilizing a core curriculum that systematically centers the resilience, resistance, agency, and contemporary contributions of Black, Indigenous, Latine, Asian American, Pacific Islander, and LGBTQ+ communities.



- **Universal Design and Complex Texts:** To bridge the gap between high-level historical inquiry and variable student reading proficiency, best practices require materials designed around Universal Design for Learning (UDL). High-quality curricula must provide integrated literacy scaffolds, vocabulary tiering, and multimedia extensions. This ensures that Multilingual Learners and students receiving Special Education services can critically analyze complex, authentic texts alongside their peers, rather than being relegated to simplified or lower-cognitive-demand work.

ANALYSIS OF SITUATION

Adopting a common 6-12 Social Studies curriculum provides a vertically articulated pathway from the Western/Eastern Hemispheres in middle school to Modern World History, US History, Government, and Economics in high school.

A central adoption reduces "instructional lift" for teachers and ensures that students experiencing learning interruptions or housing transitions encounter a familiar instructional scope regardless of which PPS school they attend. Furthermore, the field test revealed a critical need for human-translated materials for our 1,000+ Spanish Dual Language Immersion (DLI) students. By selecting vendors like TCi and Cengage, the district ensures that DLI students receive the same high-quality, rigorous content as their peers in English-only classrooms, rather than relying on inaccurate machine translations.

FISCAL IMPACT

This purchase will be funded through a combination of General Funds and the 2020 School Bond. The bond will cover compensable instructional materials (physical and digital licenses), while General Funds will support professional development contracts and supplemental resources. By selecting vendors with robust built-in support, the district minimizes the future fiscal burden of teacher-led curriculum development.

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT

The recommendation is the result of a comprehensive field-testing period spanning the 2025–2026 school year.

- **Teacher Participation:** This teacher-led, data-driven initiative involved approximately 40 educators from across six middle schools and nine high schools—including NAYA and specialists in Special Education and Dual Language Immersion (DLI). Starting in December 2025, the committee utilized the Instructional Resource Bias Evaluation tool to narrow five potential vendors down to those scoring highest in Social Justice and representation. For



grades 6-8, the pilot resulted in 100% teacher approval for the final recommendations, with 55% indicating "Highly Recommend" and 45% indicating "Recommend with Reservations". For grades 9-12, the pilot resulted in an 84% teacher approval rating for the final recommendation. Cengage achieved 91% teacher validation for asset-based representation (94% for cultural traditions; 88% for visual representation). Throughout the spring of 2026, teachers conducted technical vetting for Canvas and Synergy compatibility and evaluated the "instructional lift" required to support diverse learners. Educators specifically noted that the literacy scaffolds—which received an 82% favorable rating in Modern World History and 72% in US History—directly support the district's goal of providing equitable access to complex texts.

- **Student Voice:** Feedback was collected from 938 total students, with 93% of high school students and 84.2% of middle school students providing favorable sentiment ratings regarding keeping the curriculum. Middle school data showed that 80.5% of students found the TCi materials to have a "Just Right" level of difficulty. Beyond quantitative surveys, the evaluation process prioritized deep qualitative data through a direct meeting with the Student Action Committee and a comprehensive analysis of student work produced during the pilot. Furthermore, evidence collected through classroom visits and a Community Action Project site visit ensured that student perspectives on representation, accessibility, and interest levels were central to the final selection.
- **Public Review:** Families and community members participated through in-person events and asynchronous digital review, ensuring broad access to the proposed materials. A dedicated community event allowed families to engage directly with the resources and speak with vendor representatives. In addition to survey feedback, the district facilitated targeted individual and group conversations with community members. The proposed instructional materials were formally presented and reviewed during a publicly noticed meeting of the Teaching, Learning, and Enrollment Committee, where formal public comments were accepted and reviewed. These collective public dialogues were essential for identifying perceived strengths and collaboratively discussing strategies to address curriculum limitations, ensuring the final selection aligned with district equity standards and community expectations.

TIMELINE FOR IMPLEMENTATION / EVALUATION

Implementation begins in August 2026 with vendor-led professional development for the Social Studies department. Teachers will receive training focused on inquiry-based simulations and digital literacy tools. All student materials will be ready for classroom deployment by August 2026. Success will be monitored through curriculum-embedded formative assessments, teacher/student feedback surveys, and alignment with post-secondary success indicators.



BOARD OPTIONS WITH ANALYSIS

- **Recommendation:** Approve the adoption of TCi (6-8 and HS Economics), Cengage (Modern World History, US History/Government), and *The Cultural Landscape* (AP Human Geography). This action immediately aligns the district with Oregon's state standards and provides high-quality, legally compliant DLI support.
- **Alternative:** If not approved, the district will continue to utilize unaligned, outdated resources. Restarting the adoption cycle would delay standards-aligned instruction by 12 to 18 months and prolong the inequitable burden on teachers to create their own instructional materials.

CONNECTION TO BOARD GOALS

This adoption directly supports Board Goal #3 (8th-grade proficiency) and Board Goal #4 (post-secondary indicators for underserved students). By providing materials that highlight the resistance and resilience of marginalized groups, we foster an asset-based identity for our students of color. High-quality literacy scaffolds ensure that Multilingual Learners can meet rigorous graduation requirements, preparing them for post-secondary college and career success.

STAFF RECOMMENDATION

Approve the purchase and implementation of the recommended 6-12 Social Studies instructional materials for the 2026–2027 school year to close the achievement gap and provide equitable access to inquiry-based learning.

As a member of the PPS Executive Leadership Team, I have reviewed this staff report.

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ATTACHMENTS

A. Social Studies Instructional Resource Recommendation Presentation